

Mauro Porcini

Scaling Human-Centred Design in Large Organisations

b. 1975 · SVP & first Chief Design Officer, PepsiCo · formerly 3M

[portrait]

Mauro Porcini

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Porcini is the proof that design thinking can be institutionalised in a giant company. As PepsiCo's first Chief Design Officer he built a global design function from scratch — the living case study for Unit 10 on implementing design in business.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Italian designer, PepsiCo's first Chief Design Officer and previously the first CDO at 3M. He is known for building design capabilities inside large, non-design-led corporations and championing a people-centred philosophy of innovation.

"The future of business is about people in love with people."

"Design is not just about products; it's about the entire experience."

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Building a design function	Creating design capability from scratch at scale
People in love with people	A human-centred innovation philosophy
The double role of design	Strategic direction and executional craft
Design-led transformation	Embedding design across a corporation
Unicorn talent	Attracting and enabling rare cross-skilled innovators

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Secure C-suite sponsorship before scaling design
- Build cross-functional teams around user problems
- Win visible early projects to earn credibility
- Hire and protect 'unicorn' cross-disciplinary talent
- Institutionalise design in structure and culture

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Lessons from consumer goods may not transfer directly
- Depends heavily on executive sponsorship
- Practitioner narrative, limited independent evidence
- Scaling design is slow and resource-intensive
- Risk of design as veneer without power

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Built PepsiCo's global design organisation
- High-profile advocate for design leadership in industry
- *The Human Side of Innovation* a leadership reference
- Model for institutionalising design at scale
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 10 implementation

SELECTED WORKS

THE HUMAN SIDE OF INNOVATION

The Power of People in Love with People

PORCINI · 2022

DESIGN AT PEPSICO

case studies & talks

PORCINI · 2010s

THE POWER OF PEOPLE

Berrett-Koehler

PORCINI · 2022

BUILDING DESIGN CAPABILITY

industry essays

PORCINI · 2020s

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Porcini, M. (2022) *The Human Side of Innovation*. Oakland, CA: Berrett-Koehler.

McKinsey & Company (2022) 'Author Talks: PepsiCo's Mauro Porcini on meaningful design and mentorship'. Available at:

<https://www.mckinsey.com/featured-insights/mckinsey-on-books/author-talks-pepsicos-mauro-porcini-talks-meaningful-design-and-mentorship> (Accessed: 20 July 2026).